THE INDIAN CONTINGENT

Annu Rani, Neeraj Chopra, Sachin Yadav, Yash Vir Singh, Rohit Yadav (all javelin throw), Gulveer Singh (5,000m, 10,000m), Animesh Kujur (200m), Tejas Shirse (110m hurdles), Servin Sebastian (20km race walk), Priyanka Goswami, Ram Baboo, Sandeep Kumar (all 35km race walk), Praveen Chithravel, Abdulla Aboobacker (triple jump), Sarvesh Kushare (high jump), Murali Sreeshankar (long jump), Parul Chaudhary, Ankita Dhyani (both 3,000m steeplechase), Pooja (800m, 1,500m)



GULVEER SINGH

India's most improved athlete, Gulveer has knocked off three national records this year. In February, he rewrote the 5,000m mark and the following month, bettered the 10,000m record—the fastest time by an Asian this season. Then, in August, he improved on the 3,000m national record. There's more in store at the World Championships.



ANI

PARUL CHAUDHARY

When Parul Chaudhary finished sixth in the 3,000m steeplechase at the Doha Diamond League, she bettered her own national record. The same month, she smashed that mark again at the Asian Championships to take silver. With limited competitions so far, she's looking to reserve her best for the big prize.

—Shail Desai

CRICKET ▼

Back in Play

All-rounder Sneh Rana has fought her way back into India's ODI World Cup squad with renewed grit and form

On her World Cup debut in 2022, Sneh Rana smashed an unbeaten 53 against Pakistan. The all-rounder ended the tournament with 10 wickets, but India eventually missed out on the knockouts. By the end of the following year, she was out of the T20I as well as the ODI squads. "My family and friends kept me sane during those difficult times. They told me I was the best, so I kept telling myself that when I woke up each morning, while looking in the mirror and when on the ground," Rana, 31, says.

Now, she's back on the India squad for the ODI World Cup later this month. But it has taken patient rebuilding through all of last year, sticking it out on the domestic front while working on her bowling variations, putting in work on improving her hard-hitting abilities, besides focusing on her overall fitness. Even during the third edition of the Women's Premier League (WPL) in February-March this year, she was a last-minute addition to the Royal Challengers Bangalore, though she picked up six wickets in five matches. However, when she earned her call-up for the national side again for the ODI tri-series in Sri Lanka in April-May, she made it count, returning with 15 wickets—the most in the tournament—and the Player of the Series award in tow.

SPIN PUNCH
In the ODI tri-series in Sri Lanka, Rana got 15 wickets at an average of 14, winning the Player of the Series award



GETTY IMAGES

At the preparatory camp in Visakhapatnam earlier in the month, Rana spent a lot of time with the bowling coaches, fine-tuning her off spin while exchanging notes with her mates off the field. "The bonding is very strong," she says. "We've been sharing a lot of our personal experiences, a lot of team dinners. And most times, we are talking less about cricket and more about life." And how one can make the most of second chances, especially when it comes before a World Cup. ■

—Shail Desai